

EL TORBELLINO

NEWSLETTER OF SAN DIEGO ORBITEERS FREE FLIGHT CLUB



February 2026

Remotely-Triggered Dethermalizer (RDT) Revisited

By Mike Jester

The Flying Aces Club (FAC) is a very traditional organization. It seeks to preserve many of the historic aspects of the golden days of the stick and tissue model airplane hobby. Thus, balsa wood and tissue are the primary building and covering materials allowed, with very limited exceptions. In addition, the FAC rules have long stated “The use of any R/C device during FAC competition is forbidden.” As a member of the FAC I lobbied for an exception to this broad prohibition and was eventually successful in getting the Remotely-triggered Dethermalizer (RDT) Provisional Rules added in the 2025-2026 FAC rule book. Now, if the Contest Director (CD) allows it, you can use RDT on your models to lessen the length of the recovery chases and/or increase the chances of recovering your model. RDT allows you to terminate a flight once it has achieved a max (120 seconds) or if your model begins to get into trouble, e.g., it is heading for a line of trees or a cornfield.

Like many fliers, I have had my share of unintended early DTs in contests when using viscous timers. This in turn has led me to set the viscous timer too long, to avoid an early DT, which can in turn, dramatically increase the odds of having the model fly out of sight and not be recovered. While a band burner DT with an electronic timer allows precise DT trigger times, as explained above more advantages can be gained for the same weight penalty by using an RDT system.

My Korda Victory Old Time Rubber (OTR) model is equipped with RDT. It really needs this feature as it will consistently fly maxes (120+ seconds). Use of RDT was allowed by Tom Arnold, the Contest Director (CD) at the 2025 WESTFAC contest in Buckeye, Arizona. I flew my Korda Victory model in that contest and won a Kanone in the OTR Fuselage event flying the same after scoring three maxes.

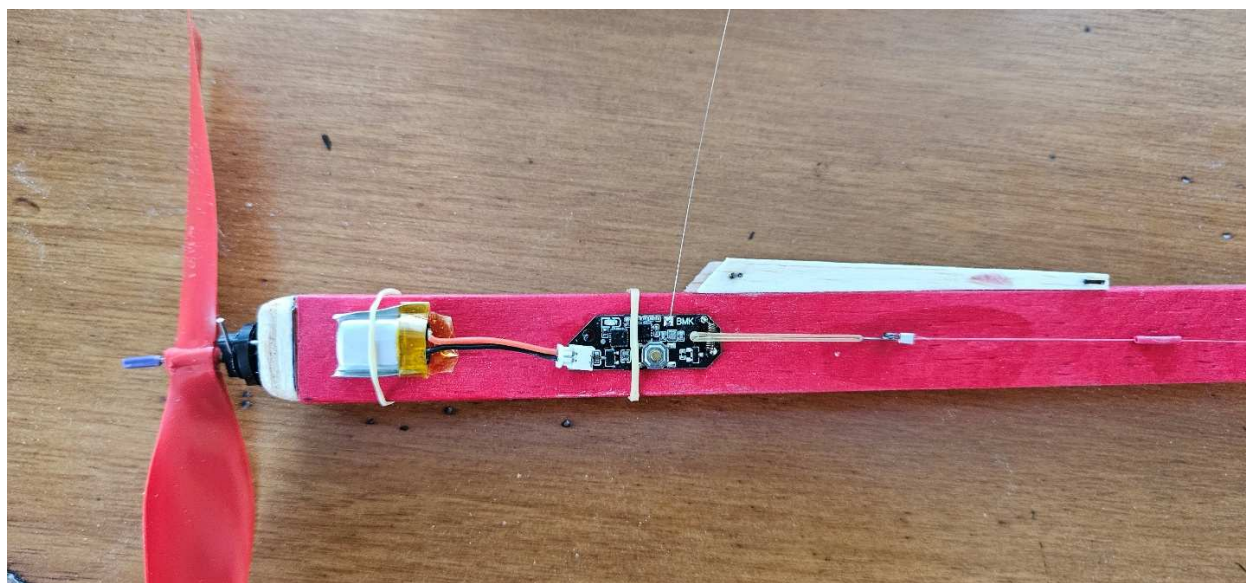


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On my Korda C I used an Airtek receiver and miniature servo as shown in the photograph below. The receiver and LiPo battery are held by rubber bands to a segment of 1/16-inch balsa wood sheet removably held to a tab on the fuselage with a plastic screw. When I push a button on a hand-held mirror the receiver causes the servo arm to swing rearwardly, releasing the tensioned DT line and allowing the stab to pivot to a 45-degree angle.



Recently I have been using a BMK band burner RDT from Volare Products. I mount this RDT system on each model with rubber bands and a CF peg glued in the fuselage fits through a hole in the PC board. I can easily transfer the on-board RDT PC board and 25 mA LiPo battery from model to model. The picture below shows this setup on my Three Nite P-20 model. The weight of the RDT circuit board and LiPo battery shown is about 3 grams.



I would not use RDT on scale models due to the significant weight penalty it can impose on such models and the negative impact on their aesthetics. Scale models typically have less of a chance of being lost in a fly away due to their less efficient flight performance than OTR models.

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dbartick@4-warddesign.com

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MPykelny@dslextrreme.com

Greg Hutchison(619) 465-7698
hutchison2262@gmail.com

ORBITEER TASK LEADERS:

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Mike Pykelny.....(858) 748-6235
MPykelny@dslextrreme.com

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MPykelny@dslextrreme.com

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Open Position(xxx) xxx-xxxx
yourname@volunteer

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Jake Olefsky(760) 815-3225
jake@olefsky.com

Newsletter Editor / Membership Cordinator

Howard Haupt(858) 272-5656
hlhaupt1033@att.net

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Howard Haupt
3860 Ecochee Avenue
San Diego, CA 92117-4622

THE FINE PRINT THE FINE PRINT

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www.SanDiegoOrbiteers.com

CONTRIBUTORS THIS ISSUE:

Mike Pykelny
Don Bartick



PHOTO CREDITS THIS ISSUE :

Mike Jester 1, 2
Arline Bartick 3, 5-7





Orbiteers Monthly Contest
January 25th
- M.Pykelný

8 AM IFR 45°F
Fog lifted by 9 AM, little drift

Five entrants:

P-30 1st Stan No fly off
2nd Greg
3rd Mike
4th David

HLG 1st Stan
2nd Chris

Power 1st Mike



Contest Report--Southwest Regional's Eloy, AZ - D.Bartick

Arline and I have been attending the SW Regional's the past 30+ years. Missed very few. It is always a very well-run contest. Managed by the Phoenix Model Airplane Club. It includes AMA, SAM, FAC and FAI events. At one point, back in the day, hundreds attended. But not anymore. I'm didn't see the final count, but it wasn't more than 50 participants.

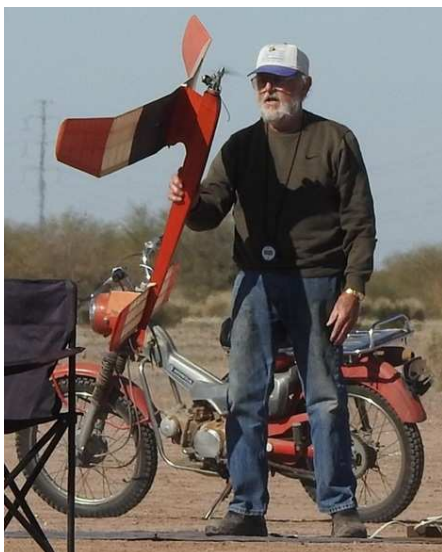
The weather was exceptional. 40+ degrees at the start each day and reaching into the 70's by early afternoon. The winds were calm to maybe 3 MPH. Just wonderful!

FAI events had good competition. Not sure about SAM. They operate independently on another section of the field. FAC had 3 participants, duking it out in a couple Mass Launches. Most of the AMA events had 3 or less participants. A couple exceptions. The most competed event was P-30 with 8 entries. I came away with 2nd. Again, P-30 continues to be the most popular event across the world stage. We can all thank the Orbiteers for its inception and a special tribute to John Oldenkamp and Harry Steinmetz. If you haven't attended the SW regional before, put it on your bucket list. The distance to Eloy, AZ is about the same as to Lost Hills from San Diego. One difference is the gas prices when you reach AZ. At least a dollar less than CA. That's my report.

Don Bartick



2026 SW Regional's – Above and to right →
(Photos by Arline Bartick)



Return to Indoor Flying---Don Bartick



February 8th marked the 6th time that we have flown Indoors at the Los Coches Creek Middle School gym. The 2 competitions were A-6 and Catapult Glider.

Five flyers registered and 5 entered the events. 5 in A-6 and 1 in Catapult Glider. The best 3 of 6 official attempts were scored and added together. The results were:

A-6

1 st Greg Hutchison	508 seconds
2 nd Don Bartick	332 seconds
3 rd Robert Huffstutler	207 seconds

Catapult Glider

1 st Don Bartick	141 seconds
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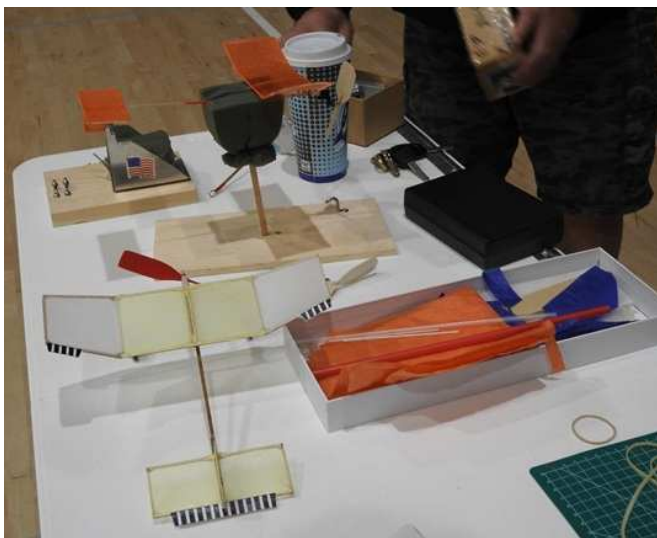
Once again, we fell short on attendance. Having 5 participants contribute funds did not come within 75% of the rental fee. With additional contributions, we got to 60% of the rental fee of \$318 for 4 hours. This places a burden on the Orbiteers Treasury to make up the difference. As such, we can't continue without more participants. The gym is the best indoor venue we have ever had. With a 27-foot height to the center girder. Higher if you fly above the wooden girders. Some successfully do. It makes indoor flying a joy. So, everyone reading this report, please try indoor or return to indoor. The weather is great and the chases are very, very short.

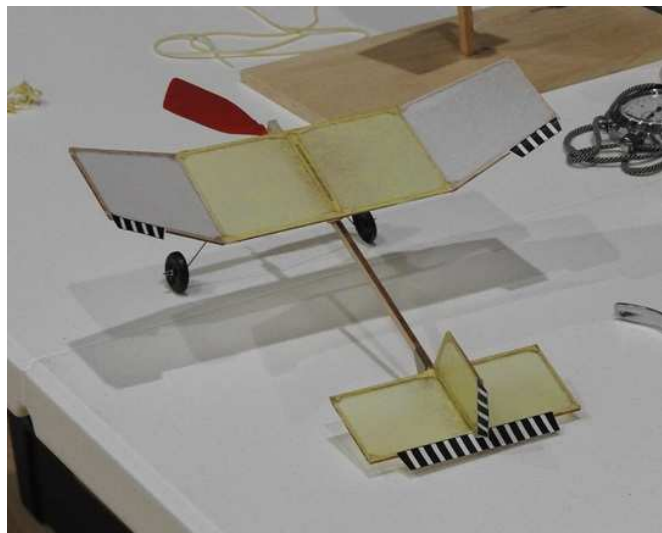
Next Indoor is scheduled April 12th for 4 hours-8am to noon. The cost to participate is \$30 minimum. Additional contributions are welcomed. Competition events are free. Events will be P-18 and Embryo. Of course, bring whatever you have to fun fly.

WE NEED MORE PARTICIPANTS. We can't sustain renting this great venue without more participants. Please consider Indoor Free Flight. It's really a fun version of Free Flight.

Up-up and away!

- Don





San Diego Orbiteers Flying Schedule 2026 Taibi Field Perris, Ca

<u>Primary Date</u>	<u>Rain Date</u>	<u>Event</u>
January 25 January 16,17,18	No Date	P-30/Glider/Power SW Regional, Eloy, Az)
February 15	February 22	Coupe/Glider/Power
March 22	March 29	OT/NOS Rubber/Glider/Power
April 19	April 26	P-30 /Glider/Power
May 17	May 24	Coupe/Glider/Power
June 14	June 28	OT/NOS Rubber/Glider/Power
July 19	July 26	P-30/Glider/Power
August 16	Aug 23	Coupe/Glider/Power
September Hills, Ca	(TBD)	Free Flight Championships, Lost
September 20	September 27	OT/NOS Rubber/Glider/Power
October 18	October 25	P-30/Glider/Power
November	13,14&15	Dual Clubs, Lost Hill, Ca
November 22	November 29	Coupe/Glider/Power
December 13	No Date	Make-up

MP
12/25

February 2026 Outdoor Contest

February 28 and March 1

7 a.m. Set up

8 a.m. Pilots meeting

11:30 a.m. Last flight



Saturday 8 a.m. Pilot's meeting

Saturday's Mass Launches

WW 1: Sponsored by Dave Loafhouse

8:30 a.m. WWI Mass Launch Photo

8:35 a.m. WWI Mass Launch

WW II:

9:30 a.m. WWII Mass Launch Photo

9:35 a.m. WWII Mass Launch

Sunday 8 a.m Pilot's meeting

Sundays Mass Launches

Greve/Thompson Sponsored by Bob Hodes

8:30 a.m. Greve/Thompson Mass Launch Photo

8:35 a.m. Greve/Thompson Mass Launch

Sky Bunny Sponsored by William Scott

9:30 a.m. Sky Bunny Mass Launch Photo

9:35 a.m. Sky Bunny Mass Launch

Fly Either Day*

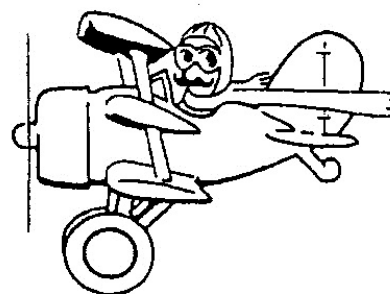
1. FAC Rubber Scale **Sponsored by Anonymous**
2. Embryo Endurance (ROG) **Sponsored by William Scott**
3. Golden Aged Combined
4. Old Time Rubber Stick and Fuselag (hand launched)
5. FAC 2Bit +1 and Jimmy Allen combined (ROG)
6. Phantom Flash (ROG)
7. Jet Catapult

***All flights must be made on the same day.**

CD: William Scott
wscott127@mac.com
(619) 701-2457

Studio 6 Suites
480 South Redlands
(951) 943-5577

SAN DIEGO ORBITEERS
Howard L. Haupt / Editor
3860 Ecochee Avenue
San Diego, California 92117-4266



WHAT'S HAPPENING -

- February 15, 2026 - San Diego Orbiteer Outdoor Monthly
Taibi Flying Field, Perris CA, 7:30 start time.
Events: Coupe / Glider / Power
- February 28, 2026 - Scale Staffel Outdoor Contest
and March 1, 2026
(See enclosed flyer for all the details)
- March 22, 2026 - San Diego Orbiteer Outdoor Monthly
Taibi Flying Field, Perris CA, 7:30 start time.
Events: OT-NOS Rubber / Glider / Power